The spread of Buddhism in China owes a great deal to the work of Indian monks who came to China, translated Buddhist scriptures into Chinese, preached the main tenets of their faith and helped establish the correct ritual practices and ceremonies. This was reinforced by the accounts of Indian sacred places associated with Lord Buddha by Chinese monks travelling in the reverse direction to India.

The most detailed account is contained in Xuan Zang's *Great Tang Records of the Western Region* . Thanks to him we have a relatively reliable historical narrative concerning the Indian empire of King Harsha Siladitya, who ruled from 590 CE to 647 CE , as also of Nalanda University, where Xuan Zang himself spent nearly six years, first as a student and then as a teacher.

We are left with a picture of northern India as a relatively rich region, Harsha's capital city of Kannauj itself being an impressive and populous city. Compared to the account left behind by Fa Xian of a visit 200 years earlier, Xuan Zang finds Buddhism even more diminished in India, with most places of pilgrimage in ruins or with only a few surviving monasteries. Harsha is praised for extending patronage to Buddhism, though the Hindu faith is clearly dominant by this time.

Despite the decline of Buddhism in India, Xuan Zang finds that the monastic university of Nalanda retains its reputation as one of the leading intellectual centres in Asia, attracting students from several countries including China. It not only teaches Buddhist theology and philosophy, but also more secular subjects like mathematics, astronomy and medicine. Xuan Zang's account of his stay in Nalanda gives us an idea of how extensive the university was, with 10,000 resident monks and a faculty of the most gifted teachers. He describes the rigorous requirements to be fulfilled by those wishing to enter the university.

The university had an extensive library and several lecture theatres, and teaching included regular debates moderated by its experienced teachers. Xuan Zang studied the esoteric Yogacara under the celebrated abbott Silabhadra, who was already 100 years old when Xuan Zang arrived at Nalanda. The reputation of India in China as a centre of advanced